

Ψευδο-Φωκυλίδης ὁ Γνωμολόγος

Sentences of Pseudo-Phocylides

eul_aid: oss

Period: Ῥωμαϊκή [Roman](#)
Dialect: Κοινή [Koine](#)
Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)
Format: Πεζός [Prose](#)
Affiliation: [Jewish](#)

Pseudo-Phocylides is the name given to an unknown Jewish author who lived during the early Roman Empire, likely between the 1st century BCE and the 1st century CE. The author's precise identity and location are uncertain, but modern scholars generally believe they were a Jew living in the Greek-speaking diaspora, possibly in Alexandria.

This author composed a single surviving work, a 230-line hexameter poem known as the Sentences of Phocylides. The poem is a collection of ethical maxims presented as if written by the much earlier Greek poet Phocylides of Miletus. This false attribution was a common literary strategy of the time, used to give the text greater authority and appeal to a wide Greco-Roman audience.

The work successfully blends Jewish law and wisdom, drawn from biblical books like Leviticus and Deuteronomy, with popular Greek philosophical ideas from Stoic and Pythagorean traditions. The significance of the Sentences lies in this synthesis. It represents a key example of Hellenistic Jewish literature, where Jewish thinkers actively engaged with Greek culture. The poem aimed to show that Jewish ethical teachings were compatible with the best of Greek thought, serving as a cultural bridge.

For centuries, it was mistaken for a genuine work of archaic Greek wisdom and was quoted by early Christian writers. Its true origins were not uncovered until the 19th century. Today, it is valued as an important document for understanding how Jewish communities in the ancient Mediterranean world presented their values within the dominant Greco-Roman culture.

Works (1)

- Γνώμαι · [Sentences](#) · 41 passages

Other Jewish Authors

- Ἀνώνυμος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · [Alexandrian Philosopher Anonymous](#) · 1 work
- Φίλων ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · [Philo of Alexandria](#) · 40 works